

How to write a CHI paper

A simple, straightforward guide to get your research accepted at CHI.



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Wouldn't it be nice to write your CHI papers peacefully like this?

So, you might be a bit like I used to be. Dreaming of seeing your work presented at CHI, the premier conference in human-computer interaction (HCI)? You envision yourself on stage, sharing your groundbreaking research with the brightest minds in the field. But there's a catch: CHI is so notoriously competitive. And I used to get rejected. Like hard. But then, over the years, I figured out their formula and I want share some of this knowledge to help you beat the CHI submission process.

CHI's gates of steel and stone

Let's face the reality: getting a paper accepted at CHI is about as easy as teaching a child to file taxes. With an acceptance rate hovering around 26%, only the cream of the crop makes it through the rigorous review process. But what exactly makes a CHI paper stand out?

The simple secret lies in originality, significance, research quality, handling of prior work, and presentation. Your paper must do more than reiterate existing knowledge; it must push the boundaries of HCI, offer a fresh perspective, and deliver tangible contributions. Think of your paper as the software update that doesn't break everything, prompting a shift in how we think and act within the field.

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One simple question to rule 8,000 words

Every compelling CHI paper begins with a problem that leads to a burning research question. This question serves as your direction. It guides your research journey. And it shapes your ultimate contribution. But not every spark ignites discovery. Some questions whisper, others roar. A good research question is clear, focused, and grounded in reality. It's better to chase lightning than to count raindrops. You want a question that begs to be answered, a question that can be tackled through rigorous research and measured for impact.

Treat your research question as the load-bearing wall in a house: if it fails, the roof collapses. So, take some time to craft a question that is researchable, arguable,

feasible, and relevant to your chosen topic. In an ideal world, you pick your method after you set your question. They are the tools you use to answer your research question.

The secret trinity of any CHI paper

Here's my take on writing CHI papers. Think of them as a three-act structure. Act one sets the stage, introducing the problem and its significance. Act two shows off your solution, fleshing out your approach and methodology. Act three brings to light the impact of your work, putting your contributions in scientific context and ruminating on future implications.

1. Context: The Problem

First, define the problem you're addressing. Why does it matter? Who is affected? What are the current limitations? Authors anchor their work in past findings and theories. They map out how previous efforts approached similar questions and where they fell short. They look at which groups have felt the impact, whether those interventions addressed cultural or organizational considerations, and how well they fit with current practices in HCI.

You want to show here that the problem does not stand isolated. Instead, it emerges from a long conversation about user needs, design principles, and technological growth. Such context prepares the reader for a new contribution that can progress beyond familiar territory. This shows them that the upcoming study does not rest on guesswork but on an informed understanding of what came before it.

2. Content: The Solution

You frame your contribution by detailing how it responds to the identified needs and builds on prior knowledge. How does your approach address the problem? What are its key components? What methodologies did you use? Readers see how you

structured your chosen methods, whether you worked with prototypes, conducted interviews, or analyzed existing data. Ideally, you are presenting a solution that addresses both technical and social dimensions.

Each component of your solution emerges for a reason, from the foundational design choices to the metrics you selected to measure its effectiveness. You are doing more than delivering a solution. You are placing an idea on firm footing. So that other researchers can see precisely how your solution might stand up against competing approaches and find its place in ongoing scholarly discussions.

3. Contribution: The Impact

Finally, you describe how your work helps researchers and practitioners see issues from fresh perspectives. What are the tangible benefits of your solution? How does it advance HCI knowledge? What new opportunities does it create? Perhaps it informs better design principles, guides new tool development, or encourages more inclusive user experiences.

Each gain, whether it involves improved usability, broadened access, or strengthened cooperation, signals that your effort here was not just a theoretical exercise. Instead, it creates openings for future investigations and encourages others to build on these steps you have presented. The result of a good contribution is a lasting mark that transforms previously held assumptions and sets a more effective course for HCI research.

Some practical tips

Now that you understand the core principles of writing a CHI paper, let's dig into some practical tips to help you write better CHI papers:

- **Embrace the short revision cycle.** Familiarize yourself with CHI's unique revision process, which allows for a single round of revisions within a tight timeframe. This means your initial submission must be polished and your revisions strategic and focused.
- **Target the right subcommittee.** CHI is like a mosaic of minds with diverse subcommittees, each with its own quirks and expectations. Research the subcommittees carefully to identify the best fit for your work and tailor your submission accordingly.
- **Make your figures do the heavy lifting.** A picture is worth a thousand words, especially at CHI. Ensure your figures are not just aesthetically pleasing but also informative and self-explanatory. A reviewer should be able to grasp the essence of your paper simply by looking at the figures and tables.
- **Don't test the reviewers' patience.** Reviewers are your audience, treat them with respect. Avoid overstating your claims, using insensitive language, or submitting poorly formatted paper riddled with typos. These seemingly small details can significantly impact a reviewer's first impression of your work (and it's hard to backpedal after that).
- **Structure your paper as a pattern that patterns itself.** Think of your paper as a set of nested Russian dolls. The abstract is a condensed version of the introduction, which in turn is a condensed version of the full paper. Each section should build upon the previous one. They provide increasing levels of detail while maintaining a clear and consistent narrative. I explain this [in detail in my CHI writing course](#).

So, keep in mind that redwoods grow longer than roses bloom. Building the muscle to write good CHI papers takes time. It requires dedication, meticulous research, and passion for pushing the boundaries of HCI. But with the right mindset and my tips, you'll be well on your way to CHI success.

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Next steps

Ready to explore more of the CHI lore? Here are three resources to fuel your journey

1. The current [CHI 2025 conference website](#) and [previous CHI 2024 program](#). You'll find all the resources for all things CHI, including submission guidelines, deadlines, and links to past conference proceedings, and talks.
2. My ['How to Write CHI Papers' Podcast](#) and [YouTube playlist](#): My interviews with CHI researchers, offering inspiration and insights.
3. [My CHI course website](#): My comprehensive online course designed to help you master the art of CHI paper writing, from ideation to submission.

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